PGCE Secondary Education: Cross-Subject Reading List

Principles of Learning & Curriculum Design in Education

This reading list covers the theories of learning, curriculum design, adaptive teaching, professional practice and Level 7 criticality that apply across all subjects. For subject-specific pedagogy reading, please refer to your specific subject's module reading list on Talis Aspire. If you want to explore your own subject's evidence base further, Ofsted's Curriculum Research Reviews *has a research review and/or subject report for every National Curriculum subject.*

The readings below are intended as a starting point rather than an exhaustive reading list. At Level 7, you are expected to engage critically with both seminal and contemporary educational scholarship, drawing upon additional peer-reviewed and subject-specific literature relevant to your assignment. Strong assignments demonstrate depth of engagement with carefully selected literature rather than attempting to reference every source listed here.

HOW PUPILS LEARN: THEORIES, MISCONCEPTIONS AND COGNITIVE DEVELOPMENT

Reading to support understanding, analysis and critique of seminal and current theories of learning.

Seminal Educational Theory

- **Piaget, J.** (1952) *The Origins of Intelligence in Children.* Book | Recommended
- **Vygotsky, L.S.** (1978) *Mind in Society: The Development of Higher Psychological Processes.* Book | Essential
- **Bruner, J.S.** (1960) *The Process of Education.* Book | Essential

Contemporary Educational Theory

- **Pritchard, A.** (2018) *Ways of Learning: Learning Theories for the Classroom.* 4th edn. Book | Essential
- **Aubrey, K. and Riley, A.** (2022) *Understanding and Using Educational Theories.* 3rd edn. Book | Recommended

Cognitive Science

- **Willingham, D.T.** (2021) *Why Don't Students Like School?* 2nd edn. Book | Essential
- **Rosenshine, B.** (2012) 'Principles of Instruction: Research-Based Strategies That All Teachers Should Know.' *American Educator*, 36(1), pp.12–19, 39. Article | Essential

Evidence Reviews

- **Education Endowment Foundation** (2021) *Cognitive Science Approaches in the Classroom: A Review of the Evidence.* Document | Recommended

DESIGNING AND SEQUENCING THE CURRICULUM

Reading to support the design of a sequence of lessons and justification of content selection.

Curriculum Theory

- **Young, M.** (2014) *Knowledge and the Future School.* Book | Essential
- **Ashbee, R.** (2021) *Curriculum: Theory, Culture and the Subject Specialisms.* Book | Essential
- **Counsell, C.** (2018) 'Taking Curriculum Seriously.' *Impact.* Article | Essential

Curriculum Implementation

- **Myatt, M.** (2018) *The Curriculum: Gallimaufry to Coherence.* Book | Recommended
- **Sealy, C.** (ed.) (2020) *The researchED Guide to the Curriculum.* Book | Recommended

ASSESSMENT AND FEEDBACK

Reading to support formative assessment and responsive teaching within the lesson sequence.

Seminal Assessment Research

- **Black, P. and Wiliam, D.** (1998) 'Inside the Black Box: Raising Standards Through Classroom Assessment.' *Phi Delta Kappan*, 80(2), pp.139–148. Article | Essential

Contemporary Assessment

- **Wiliam, D.** (2018) *Embedded Formative Assessment.* 2nd edn. Book | Essential

Adaptive teaching and inclusive learning environments

Reading to support analysis of learner needs and justification of adaptations to create an inclusive learning environment.

Inclusive Pedagogy

- **Florian, L. and Black-Hawkins, K.** (2011) 'Exploring Inclusive Pedagogy.' *British Educational Research Journal*, 37(5), pp.813–828. Article | Essential
- **Webster, R.** (ed.) (2019) *Including Children and Young People with SEND in Learning and Life*. Book | Recommended

Evidence Reviews

- **Education Endowment Foundation** (2020) *Special Educational Needs in Mainstream Schools: Guidance Report*. Document | Essential

Current Policy and Professional Expectations

- **Department for Education** (2026) *Every Child Achieving and Thriving*. Policy Paper | **Essential** |

Professional practice, reflection and evidence-informed teaching

Initial Teacher Education

- **Capel, S., Leask, M., Younie, S., Hidson, E. and Lawrence, J.C.** (2022) *Learning to Teach in the Secondary School: A Companion to School Experience.* 9th edn. Book | Essential
- **Gibbons, S., Glackin, M., Rushton, E., Towers, E. and Brock, R.** (eds.) (2023) *Becoming a Teacher: Issues in Secondary Education.* 6th edn. Book | Recommended

Reflective Practice

- **Pollard, A. et al.** (2023) *Reflective Teaching in Secondary Schools.* 6th edn. Book | Recommended

Evidence Reviews

- **Education Endowment Foundation** *Teaching and Learning Toolkit.* Online resource | Essential

Practitioner Scholarship

- **Sherrington, T. and Caviglioli, O.** (2020) *Teaching WalkThrus: Five-Step Guides to Instructional Coaching*. Book | Recommended

DEVELOPING CRITICALITY AT LEVEL 7

Critical engagement with research is one of the biggest areas for development across the programme at master's level. Trainees consistently find it easier to describe and summarise sources than to evaluate and compare them, moving from "what does this source say?" to "how convincing is this, on what grounds, and compared with what?" is the single biggest lever on Level 7 marks in the curriculum design rationale.

- ***Claim:*** *What exactly is being claimed, and how strongly (a tentative finding vs. a firm recommendation)?*
- ***Warrant:*** *What evidence or reasoning supports the claim? Is the evidence proportionate to how strongly the claim is made?*
- ***Context:*** *Who was studied, where, and does that context transfer to secondary education in England / your subject / your setting?*
- ***Comparison:*** *How does this source agree or disagree with others you've read? Where there's disagreement, why different methods, different contexts, different theoretical starting points?*
- ***Position:*** *Having weighed this, what is your own judgement and can you defend it?*

This isn't a checklist to work through mechanically in the writing itself; it's a way of reading that should surface the comparative, evaluative content the rationale needs.

Critical Reading and Academic Writing

- **Wallace, M. and Wray, A.** (2026) *Critical Reading and Writing for Postgraduates*. 5th edn. Book | **Essential** | The core text for developing critical reading, structured critique, literature synthesis and academic argument at postgraduate level.
- **Ridley, D.** (2019) *The Literature Review: A Step-by-Step Guide for Students*. 3rd edn. Book | **Essential** | Excellent guidance on synthesising literature, comparing perspectives and constructing coherent academic arguments rather than summarising sources individually.
- **Poulson, L. and Wallace, M.** (eds.) (2004) *Learning to Read Critically in Teaching and Learning*. Book | **Recommended** | Education-specific guidance on critically reading and evaluating educational research through authentic research examples.

Critical Thinking and Academic Argument

- **Fisher, A.** (2011) *Critical Thinking: An Introduction*. 2nd edn. Book | **Recommended** | Develops understanding of evaluating arguments, evidence and reasoning.
- **Cottrell, S.** (2023) *Critical Thinking Skills: Effective Analysis, Argument and Reflection*. 4th edn. Book | **Recommended** | Practical guidance for developing critical analysis, academic argument and reflective writing.
- **Williams, K.** (2022) *Getting Critical*. 3rd edn. Book | **Recommended** | A concise introduction to critical reading, evaluation and academic writing strategies.

Understanding Master's Level (Level 7)

- **Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education (QAA).** (2024) *The Frameworks for Higher Education Qualifications of UK Degree-Awarding Bodies (FHEQ)*. Guidance Document | **Essential** | Explains the knowledge, critical understanding, autonomy and analytical skills expected of Master's-level work, including the Level 7 qualification descriptor.
- UniSkills, Edge Hill University Library & Learning Services. Webpage | **Recommended** | Workshops, online toolkits and 1:1 support for academic writing and criticality at Level 7